

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ALGERIA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The oasis town of **In Salah**, deep in the Algerian Sahara, produced one of the most remarkable community environmental stands the country has seen. When the government pressed **shale-gas fracking** into the desert — over the finite, non-renewable fossil aquifer the whole south depends on for its water — the people of In Salah rose to defend that water in a sustained, disciplined, water-grounded mobilisation that forced the government to **suspend** the fracking. The suspension proved reversible, and the extraction is state-led and driven hard; but In Salah showed that even in a semi-closed, military-backed state, a community defending its water can be heard. That fight — the scarce, irreplaceable Saharan water against the extraction that threatens it — is the ground on which environmental effort in Algeria stands.

The people of In Salah drew on tools available — carefully — to communities across Algeria, and the strongest of them is the water itself. The **water argument** — the defence of a finite, non-renewable fossil aquifer the whole desert depends on — is a unifying, apolitical cause that binds a community as few issues can, and it was the ground In Salah stood on. The **environmental review and water-protection rules** the extraction is legally supposed to satisfy can be scrutinised and pressed where they are skipped or defective. The gas footprint invites **international climate scrutiny**, a lever reachable through the world's climate frameworks and attention. The **technical and scientific evidence** — the hydrology of the aquifer, the contamination risk of fracking — grounds the whole case. And the **international and civil-society channels** carry it where the domestic space is closed. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The gas economy is the state's foundation, so the extraction is driven hard and cannot be openly defied. The political space is semi-closed and military-backed, and open defiance is perilous. The In Salah suspension, real as it was, proved reversible. And the south is marginalised, the water finite. So the work must be careful, within-system, grounded always in the water, and strictly neutral on the politics — and the honest aim is to scrutinise the extraction, defend the water, and press for a pause or a limit, not to openly defy a state-led project. Above all, protect the people who take part.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot openly defy a state-led extraction in a semi-closed state, and attempting it is perilous. What you can do is what In Salah did: ground the fight in the water — the scarce, irreplaceable aquifer everyone depends on — document the harm, scrutinise the extraction against the rules it must satisfy, invoke international climate and technical scrutiny, and carry the case through the community and the international channels, staying strictly neutral on the politics and protecting everyone involved.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Algeria is a hard, semi-closed setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline. This is not a fight you win by confrontation with a military-backed state over its economic foundation. It is a careful, water-grounded, within-system effort whose realistic prize is scrutiny, a pause, or a limit — as In Salah won a suspension — not an open defeat of state-led extraction. Frame everything around the water, never around the politics, and treat the safety of those involved as the first rule.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power over the extraction rests with the state and the national energy enterprise, backed by the military, in a semi-closed system where open political defiance is perilous and the south is marginalised. The channels a careful effort can reach are the **oasis and desert communities** whose water is at stake, the **scientists and technical experts** who hold the hydrological case, the **civil society** that operates in a constrained space, and the **international climate, water, and human-rights frameworks** that can scrutinise from outside. Map, before you act, which of these you can reach safely.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The extraction advances by state decision and the national enterprise's operations. There is limited domestic permitting to contest openly, but the extraction is supposed to satisfy environmental-review and water-protection rules, and those are a point of entry — where they are skipped, defective, or ignored, a documented, water-grounded case can press them. Beyond that, the strongest entry point is the one In Salah used: the community's stake in its water, carried carefully and joined to technical and international scrutiny.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water first: which aquifer the extraction draws on or threatens, and what the hydrology shows. Follow the gas: which foreign partners and financiers are involved, and what climate and environmental commitments they answer to. Follow the rules: which environmental-review and water-protection requirements the project must, in law, satisfy. The leverage lies in the water, the international scrutiny of the gas, and the gap between the rules and the practice.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is weak against a state-led project. The watchers a case can realistically engage are external and technical: the international climate and water frameworks, the scientists and hydrologists who can document the aquifer's fragility, the international human-rights and environmental bodies, and the constrained but real civil society and diaspora. These are the institutions a careful, water-grounded case is built to reach.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Algerian effort against state-led extraction yields an easy or certain win, and honesty requires saying so — the In Salah suspension itself proved reversible. But In Salah also proved that a careful, water-grounded, apolitical community stand can force a real pause and be heard even in this space. The single most decisive move is **grounding everything in the water** — the finite, irreplaceable aquifer — because it is the one cause that unites a community, stays clear of the politics that would endanger it, and carries moral and technical weight at home and abroad. The technical and scientific evidence is essential; the international climate scrutiny is a real external lever; and the community's stake is the foundation In Salah built on. The realistic prize is scrutiny, a pause, or a limit — and, always, people kept safe.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the threat to the scarce, non-renewable water, the contamination risk, the desert's fragility. **Which water is at stake?** — the fossil aquifer, the oasis supply, the source the community depends on. **Which rule or standard does the project have to satisfy?** — the environmental

review, the water-protection rules, the climate commitments of its foreign partners. **Which channel can be reached safely?** — the community, the scientists, the international frameworks. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by staying water-grounded, apolitical, and careful. Pick the harm where the threat to the water is clearest and the community's stake strongest — as In Salah did.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, grounded always in the water. **Layer one: the harm to the water** — the hydrology of the aquifer, its finite and non-renewable nature, the contamination and depletion risk the extraction carries. **Layer two: the rule and the footprint** — the environmental-review and water-protection requirements the project must satisfy, and the climate footprint of the gas that invites international scrutiny. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which technical, community, or international channel to reach, and the absolute discipline of staying neutral on the politics and protecting everyone involved. A case built on hydrology and the finite water — clear, technical, and apolitical — is the one that carried In Salah, and the one that carries weight without endangering those who make it.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **water record**: the hydrological studies of the aquifer, its recharge (or lack of it), the community's dependence, the contamination risk of fracking. Gather the **rule-and-footprint record**: the environmental-review and water-protection requirements, the climate commitments of the foreign partners, the gas footprint. Gather the **channel record**: the scientists and hydrologists, the constrained civil society, the international climate, water, and human-rights frameworks, the diaspora. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work stays water-grounded and apolitical, and that no one is exposed to a state that punishes open defiance.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COMMUNITY AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

In Salah's power was the whole community united around its water. Build that coalition carefully: the **oasis and desert communities** whose water is at stake, the **scientists and hydrologists** who hold the technical case, the **constrained civil society** that can act within the space, and the **international climate, water, and human-rights frameworks and the diaspora** that carry the case from outside. The unifying force is the water — a cause that binds farmers, families, and elders alike and stays clear of the politics that would endanger it. Build the coalition around that shared, apolitical stake, and never in a way that exposes anyone to open confrontation with the state.

STEP 4: WATER, EXTRACTION & INTERNATIONAL LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM CAREFULLY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained, the extraction is state-led and cannot be openly defied, and the work must be careful and water-grounded.

The Water Argument

The **defence of the finite, non-renewable fossil aquifer** the whole desert depends on is the strongest lever — unifying, apolitical, and carrying moral and technical weight. It was the ground In Salah stood on, and it remains the foundation of any effort here: press the harm to the water, documented and technical, above all else.

The Environmental and Water-Protection Rules

The extraction is legally supposed to satisfy **environmental-review and water-protection rules**. Where those are skipped, defective, or ignored, a documented, technical case can press them — not as open defiance, but as insistence that the state's own rules for protecting the water be met.

The International Climate and Technical Scrutiny

The gas footprint invites **international climate scrutiny** through the world's climate frameworks and attention, and the fracking's water risk invites **international technical and scientific scrutiny**. These external levers reach the extraction where the domestic space is closed, carried by scientists, international bodies, and the diaspora. Pursued together — the water, the rules, and the international scrutiny — these levers contest the harm carefully, ground everything in the water, and protect everyone involved.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always around the water. **For the community**: this is our water, finite and irreplaceable, and here is the threat — the cause that unites us and stays clear of the politics. **For the scientists and technical bodies**: here is the hydrology and the contamination risk; ground and carry it. **For the international climate and water frameworks**: here is a gas footprint and a water threat that your standards reach. **For the foreign partners and financiers**: here is a project that strains the climate and environmental commitments you answer to. **The golden rule**: keep everything grounded in the water, strictly neutral on the politics, and safe for those involved — that is what carried In Salah and what protects the people who follow it.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, but must be handled with care in a semi-closed state. Frame the story strictly around the **water**: not opposition to the state, but the defence of a scarce, irreplaceable aquifer a community depends on — the frame that gave In Salah its moral force and its safety. Carry it through the technical and scientific press, the international climate and human-rights outlets, and the diaspora networks, more than through open domestic confrontation. A few cautions govern everything: keep it water-grounded and apolitical; never frame it as defiance of the state or the military; protect everyone named or involved; and let the hydrology and the finite water carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, water-grounded, apolitical, and protective of those involved.

8A — To a scientific or hydrological body: present the aquifer's fragility and the extraction's threat, and request technical assessment and support.

8B — To an international climate framework: set out the gas footprint and the extraction's climate cost, and ask for scrutiny.

8C — To an international water body: document the threat to the finite, non-renewable aquifer and request engagement.

8D — To a foreign partner or financier: ask how the project meets the climate and environmental commitments the company answers to, with the evidence.

8E — To an international human-rights or environmental body: describe the water threat and the constrained space, carefully, and request attention.

8F — To the diaspora and solidarity networks: share the water-grounded case and ask for amplification and technical help.

8G — To the community: set out the shared, apolitical stake in the water and invite the careful coalition.

8H — To the international public: summarise the water cause and the extraction's threat, and ask for support — always without endangering anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: pull the best available hydrology on the threatened aquifer; write the one-page water case (the finite water, the threat, the rule the project must satisfy); identify the safest channel — usually the scientists or an international framework. **The fastest-moving levers:** the water argument, the technical scrutiny, and the international climate attention. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the community and the scientists first, carefully and around the water. Throughout, stay apolitical and protect everyone involved.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by definition: a state-led extraction, a semi-closed and military-backed system, a marginalised south. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not open defeat, but scrutiny, a pause, or a limit, as In Salah won. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily reach: the water argument's moral and technical weight, the international climate and human-rights scrutiny, the diaspora. And accept the honest possibility that a suspension, even when won, may be reversed — as In Salah's was — while still grounding everything in the water and protecting the people.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary drive of a gas-dependent state from capture — deals that enrich a few, extraction steered to benefit insiders. Where capture appears, respond only through the **international channels**: the climate and human-rights frameworks, the standards binding foreign partners, the documented record carried by scientists and the diaspora. Never pursue it through open domestic confrontation. **On safety and care:** this governs everything. Algeria is a semi-closed, military-backed state where open defiance is perilous. Favour the community, technical, water-body, and international channels; protect those involved; frame the work strictly around the water, never the politics; and handle the state, the military, and the foreign companies factually and neutrally. Care is essential but not paralysing — In Salah showed a careful, water-grounded effort can mobilise widely and be heard.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, grounded always in the water. The hydrological evidence feeds the water argument, the rules scrutiny, and the international climate case at once; the community and international coalition organises carefully alongside; the media carries the water frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the water threat and identify the safest channels; **months two to six**, engage the scientists, the international frameworks, the foreign partners, and the community, carefully; **beyond**, sustain the patient, water-grounded pressure toward scrutiny, a pause, or a limit. The core discipline: water-grounded, apolitical, careful, and absolute in protecting everyone involved.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Algeria is a hard, semi-closed ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the gas is not central, or that state-led extraction can be openly defied, or that the space is open — none of that is true, and the In Salah suspension itself proved reversible. What it claims is narrower and real: that In Salah showed a community defending its water can be heard even here; that the finite, irreplaceable aquifer is a unifying, apolitical cause of genuine moral and technical weight; that the extraction is supposed to satisfy rules a documented case can press; and that the gas footprint and the water threat invite international scrutiny reachable from outside. The levers are constrained, the work careful and within-system, and the realistic prize is scrutiny, a pause, or a limit rather than an open defeat. But grounded always in the water, strictly neutral on the politics, and absolute in protecting the people, that careful effort is not a lesser ambition — it is, as In Salah proved, the responsible and effective one.